

FREE RESOURCE · LEADERSHIP & FACILITATION

# Facilitation Techniques Quick Reference

12 facilitation techniques for workshops, team sessions, and strategy days — with guidance on when to use each, group size, and materials needed.

12 Techniques

Group Size Guidance

Materials Needed

CATEGORIES

- Idea Generation
- Decision & Prioritisation
- Discussion & Dialogue
- Strategy & Analysis
- Session Management

|    | Technique                                             | When to Use                                                                     | Group Size             | Materials Needed                          |
|----|-------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------|-------------------------------------------|
| 01 | <b>Round-Robin Brainstorming</b><br>IDEA GENERATION   | Warm a group up to contribute ideas equally, especially early in a session.     | 4–15                   | Flipchart, marker                         |
| 02 | <b>Silent Brainwriting</b><br>IDEA GENERATION         | Idea generation where seniority or personality could suppress quieter voices.   | 4–20                   | Sticky notes, pens                        |
| 03 | <b>Dot Voting</b><br>DECISION & PRIORITISATION        | Narrowing a long list of ideas down to the few worth discussing further.        | 5–30                   | Dot stickers, posted list                 |
| 04 | <b>World Café</b><br>DISCUSSION & DIALOGUE            | Cross-pollinating ideas on a theme across rotating small groups.                | 12–40+ (tables of 4–5) | Table paper, markers, timer               |
| 05 | <b>Fishbowl Discussion</b><br>DISCUSSION & DIALOGUE   | Deep dialogue on a sensitive or complex topic without everyone talking at once. | 8–30                   | Inner circle (4–6 chairs), outer seating  |
| 06 | <b>SWOT Analysis</b><br>STRATEGY & ANALYSIS           | Structured assessment of strengths, weaknesses, opportunities, and threats.     | 3–12                   | Four-quadrant template                    |
| 07 | <b>Affinity Mapping</b><br>IDEA GENERATION            | Clustering a large, unsorted set of ideas or comments into themes.              | 4–15                   | Sticky notes, wall space                  |
| 08 | <b>Fist to Five</b><br>DECISION & PRIORITISATION      | A fast, visual check of agreement or confidence before finalising a decision.   | Any size               | None — hands only                         |
| 09 | <b>Parking Lot</b><br>SESSION MANAGEMENT              | Capturing valuable off-topic points without derailing the session's agenda.     | Any size               | Flipchart or shared doc                   |
| 10 | <b>Six Thinking Hats</b><br>STRATEGY & ANALYSIS       | Examining a complex issue from six distinct reasoning perspectives.             | 4–12                   | Six-hat reference card                    |
| 11 | <b>Open Space Technology</b><br>DISCUSSION & DIALOGUE | Letting a large group self-organise the agenda around several related topics.   | 20–100+                | Agenda wall, sticky notes, breakout space |
| 12 | <b>Round-the-Room Check-In</b><br>SESSION MANAGEMENT  | Opening or closing a session with a quick pulse read from every participant.    | 4–20                   | None — one guiding question               |